Nagios: A Modular Monitoring Tool *for* Infrastructure and Networks

If you are looking for an enterprise class open source network, application and server monitoring tool, there is no better option than Nagios. This article explores the very popular Nagios network infrastructure monitoring tool.

It is not uncommon for the IT department in an organisation to run into problems and spend a great deal of time on troubleshooting. So there is always a need to be more proactive and prevent these issues. It is also worthwhile to optimise the performance of the infrastructure and the network. When a problem occurs, figuring it out immediately and troubleshooting it is strenuous. Most of the problems tend to build up over a period of time. Monitoring the devices and the network is crucial in preventing major issues and enhancing performance. Moreover, if the health of the IT environment is not monitored, how can one ensure efficient service to the end users? Having total visibility of your infrastructure is paramount in preventing issues and making informed decisions to shape the future of the IT environment.

Monitoring not only helps in preventing IT disasters, it also has a lot of other advantages. It enables data-driven insights and helps in decision making. We can improve productivity and performance using this data. It prevents downtime and business losses. It can also help to cut down a company's budget and increase savings. Keeping track of the performance of hardware and software resources involves having first-hand knowledge of the health of the network and a complete control over IT resource usage trends.

Introducing Nagios

There are numerous open source and commercial products in the market for monitoring the network and the infrastructure. Some of the well known open source monitoring tools are Nagios, Zabbix, Cacti, Icinga, Groundwork, OpenNMS and Hyperic. Among these, Nagios is the most powerful tool. It is a framework that is capable of monitoring a large network of around 100,000 hosts and almost all components. Nagios can be integrated with third party tools. It uses the concept of modularity via plugins, which provide support for protocols, operating systems, system metrics, applications, services, Web servers, websites, middleware, etc.

Nagios does not have any internal monitoring logic. It is unaware of what is to be monitored and contains no built-in